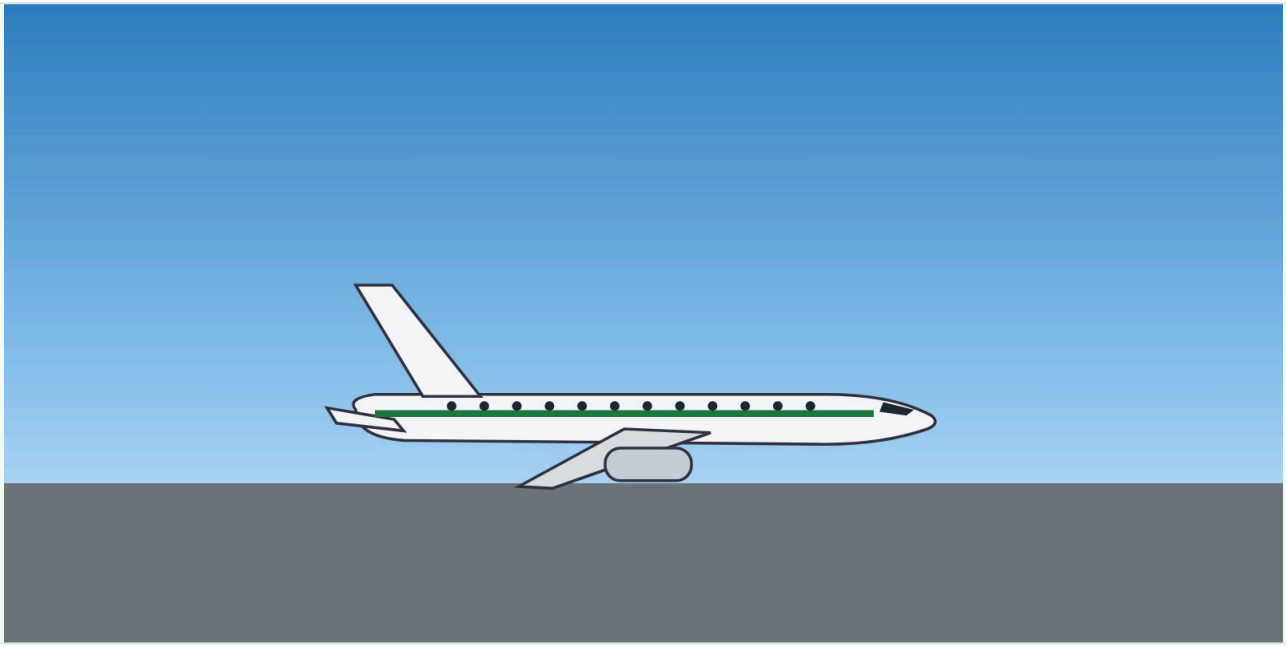
MODULE 1 · MEL PRINCIPLES

Lesson 01: MMEL, MEL and CDL

Lesson 1 of 4 · about 6 min

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Explain the purpose of the MMEL and the MEL.
- Describe how the MEL is produced and approved.
- Distinguish the MEL from the CDL.



The MEL allows safe dispatch with some equipment inoperative.

Why a MEL?

A transport aeroplane has redundant systems. The **Minimum Equipment List (MEL)** allows the operator to dispatch an aircraft with certain equipment inoperative, for a limited time and under defined conditions, while keeping an acceptable level of safety (ICAO Annex 6 Part I; EASA ORO.MLR.105).

- The **MMEL** (Master MEL) is produced by the aircraft manufacturer and approved by the State of design (for EASA, as part of the operational suitability data).
- The operator's **MEL** is based on the MMEL, adapted to its aircraft configuration, operations and procedures, and approved by its authority. It **must not be less restrictive** than the MMEL.
- Equipment **not listed** in the MEL that is required for the flight must be operative — otherwise no dispatch (unless a specific procedure applies).

CDL

The **Configuration Deviation List (CDL)**, part of the AFM, allows dispatch with certain external parts missing (for example a panel, fairing or static discharger), usually with performance penalties.

When the MEL applies

The MEL applies to dispatch — up to the point defined in the MEL preamble (commonly the start of the flight or the take-off roll). After that point, a failure is handled with the **QRH / FCOM / AOM** non-normal procedures, and the commander decides on continuation using the AFM and good airmanship.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- MMEL from the manufacturer; MEL from the operator — never less restrictive.
- Required equipment not in the MEL must work.
- CDL covers missing external parts, often with performance penalties.
- After the point defined in the preamble, use the QRH, not the MEL.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK

Can an operator's MEL be less restrictive than the MMEL?

A. Yes
B. No
C. Only for short flights
D. Only with captain's approval

Answer: B. The MEL must not be less restrictive than the MMEL.

Training material only. It does not replace the Aircraft Flight Manual, FCOM, QRH, MEL or the Domestic Airlines Operations Manual, which always take precedence.